

Negatives and their scope

Teaching guide

Make clear what is not true or not required.

Understand the distinction

In standard written English, combine not with any or use no: I do not have any cash / I have no cash. Other dialects use negative concord, such as not ... nothing; recognize it without treating its speakers as less capable.

Position changes scope. Not everyone came means some people did not come; nobody came means zero people came. Must not means prohibited, while do not have to means optional. Check what part of the meaning you are negating.

Compare the patterns

PART OF A GROUP

Not everyone agreed.

At least one person did not agree.

ZERO

Nobody agreed.

No person agreed.

OPTIONAL

You do not have to attend.

Attendance is not required.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Rewrite for standard formal English: I do not have no time.

2. Does Not all seats are taken mean every seat is empty?

3. Which means prohibited: must not / do not have to?

Use it in your own life

Write a sentence about something optional and something prohibited.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. I do not have any time.

Alternatively: I have no time.

2. No. It means at least some seats are free.

Not all and none have different meanings.

3. must not

Do not have to removes an obligation.

One possible response

You do not have to print the form. You must not share your password.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-25.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Write a sentence about something optional and something prohibited.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.